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MANUAL OF OFFICE PROCEDURE

Central Secretariat Manual of Office Procedure (CSMOP)

16th Edition • CSMOP, 2022 • DARPG

Study Notes for
**LDCE — Inspector of Posts (IP)
& PS Group 'B' Departmental Examinations**

Updated & verified against the latest orders — August 2026

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DISCLAIMER

Purpose & nature. These notes are original study material prepared by Dak Guru to help candidates understand the Central Secretariat Manual of Office Procedure (CSMOP) for the LDCE (IP) and PS Group 'B' examinations. They paraphrase and explain the Manual in simplified language; they are not a reproduction of, or a substitute for, the official Manual.

Primary source. The authoritative text is the Central Secretariat Manual of Office Procedure, 16th Edition (CSMOP, 2022), issued by the Department of Administrative Reforms & Public Grievances (DARPG), Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances & Pensions, read with the orders, circulars and notifications referenced in these notes. In case of any conflict, the official Manual and the relevant order prevail.

Currency. Content has been checked and updated against the position as available in August 2026. Government rules, procedures and timelines change from time to time. Always cross-check a critical point against the current CSMOP and the latest DARPG / DoPT order before relying on it in the examination or in office work.

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Before You Begin

About These Notes & How to Use Them

The *Manual of Office Procedure* tested in the LDCE (IP) and PS Group 'B') examinations is the **Central Secretariat Manual of Office Procedure (CSMOP)** published by the Department of Administrative Reforms & Public Grievances (DARPG). The Department of Posts, like every other Central Ministry/Department, follows the CSMOP for its secretariat-type paperwork, supplemented by its own departmental instructions.

These notes have been rebuilt around the **16th Edition — CSMOP, 2022**, which is the edition currently in force. The earlier version of these notes followed the 15th Edition (2019). The substance of many procedures is unchanged, but the 16th Edition re-organised the Manual into 16 chapters, moved all definitions into a Glossary, and modernised the language around e-Office. Wherever a rule, figure, term or authority has changed, it is flagged.

The colour-coded boxes

QUICK CONCEPT

Explains an idea in the simplest possible terms — start here if a topic is new.

EXAM FOCUS

A point examiners love: exact figures, distinctions, 'who does what', and commonly-confused pairs.

MEMORY TRICK

A mnemonic or trick to lock a list or sequence into memory.

IN e-OFFICE / eFILE

How the same step works in the electronic office (eFile / e-Office 7.0) — the direction the whole Manual is moving in.

CURRENCY ALERT

A recent change. Learn the new position; do not rely on older books here.

DEPARTMENTAL ANGLE

How the point connects to day-to-day work in the Department of Posts.

Edition & Currency Note

Which Edition Is This, and Is It Current?

CURRENCY ALERT — The current edition is the 16th (CSMOP, 2022)

The CSMOP was first published in March 1955 and has been revised many times: 13th Edition (2010), 14th Edition (2015), 15th Edition (2019) and the 16th Edition (CSMOP, 2022).

The **16th Edition**, styled “CSMOP, 2022 — Enabling the March Towards a Digital Secretariat”, is the edition in force. Its Foreword is signed by Shri V. Srinivas, Secretary, DARPG, dated 13 July 2022. It was still shown as the current CSMOP on the DARPG/DPAR website as on 1 March 2026.

A separate 'e-Office' manual (CSMeOP) was first brought out in 2012; the 16th Edition fully integrates paper and e-Office procedure into a single Manual.

The 16th Edition is built around a **four-pronged reform approach**: (1) **Delaying** (fewer levels a file passes through), (2) **Delegation** of powers, (3) **Operationalisation of the Desk Officer System**, and (4) **Digitisation of Central Registration Units (CRUs)**, together with the roll-out of **e-Office Version 7.0**. It also introduced weekly Swachhta activity, Nodal Appellate Authorities and revised grievance-redressal timelines.

What changed from the 15th Edition (2019) to the 16th Edition (2022)

Area	Old position (15th Ed.)	Current position (16th Ed., 2022)
Structure	12 chapters; a 'Definitions' chapter	16 chapters + a Glossary of terms at the end
New chapters	—	Decision Making in Govt (Ch 4); Knowledge Management (Ch 11); eOffice Digitization Framework (Ch 15); Inspection (Ch 16)
Dak handling unit	Central Registry (CR)	Central Registration Unit (CRU) — digitises/scans all dak
Lowest functionaries	'Dealing Hand' = Assistant / UDC; LDC	Dealing Officer = Assistant Section Officer (ASO) / Senior Secretariat Assistant (SSA); support = Junior Secretariat Assistant (JSA)
Working mode	Mostly paper, e-Office emerging	e-Office / eFile is the default; e-Office v7.0
Grievance redressal	Handled departmentally	CPGRAMS + Nodal Appellate Authorities; timeline reduced 30 → 21 days (Aug 2024)

EXAM FOCUS — How to read a 'para' reference

In the 16th Edition, paragraphs are numbered chapter-wise, e.g. para 5.3 = Chapter 5, para 3. These notes give the chapter name and, where useful, the para number so you can locate the rule in the official Manual.

Chapter 1

Introduction

The purpose of all public service is to meet citizens' needs and further their welfare. At the same time, those handling public business must manage public money and resources with care and prudence, strictly as per law and laid-down rules. Because of this dual duty, it is necessary in every case to keep a proper record **not only of what was done but also of why it was done.**

The efficiency of Government depends largely on sound processes and on the ability of its staff to follow them. The efficiency of a person handling secretariat work is judged by the speed and quality with which they dispose of receipts and cases while following the prescribed procedure. The CSMOP tries to balance four sometimes-conflicting considerations — speed, quality, transparency and propriety — and this balance can never be fixed rigidly, because circumstances keep changing.

QUICK CONCEPT — What the Manual is

The CSMOP is the rule-book of office procedure for the Central Secretariat, laid down by DARPG (the nodal agency for 'Organisation & Methods'). It tells functionaries how to receive dak, open and handle files, note and draft, communicate, keep records and monitor disposal — on paper and, increasingly, in e-Office.

EXAM FOCUS — First published & the 2012 milestone

The CSMOP was first published in March 1955. A separate 'Manual of e-Office Procedure' (CSMeOP) was first brought out in 2012 as the first step towards a paperless secretariat. The 16th Edition merges paper and e-Office procedure into one Manual.

The Manual allows flexibility through **Departmental Instructions** — a Department may supplement or vary the prescribed procedure, within broad limits, to suit its special needs (for example, the Department of Posts issues its own instructions). The matters on which a Department is expected to issue such instructions are listed in Appendix 1.1 of the Manual (e.g. designating Link Officers, categories of routine cases, time limits for disposal, and restriction of access to classified documents).

Chapter 2

Organisational Structure of the Government of India

The apex

The executive power of the Union formally vests in the **President**, exercised directly or through subordinate officers as per the Constitution. In practice, the President is aided and advised by a **Council of Ministers headed by the Prime Minister**, in whom the real executive power resides. The Council has three tiers of Ministers: **Cabinet Ministers, Ministers of State, and Deputy Ministers**. The Cabinet (Cabinet Ministers) shapes overall policy and works through its Committees.

How business is divided — two key sets of Rules

Under **Article 77(3)** of the Constitution, the President makes rules for the convenient transaction of Government business:

(a)

Government of India (Allocation of Business) Rules, 1961 (“AoB Rules”) — divide the business of Government among Ministries/Departments.

Government of India (Transaction of Business) Rules, 1961 (“ToB Rules”) — define the authority, responsibility and obligations of each Department, and specify which cases must go to the President, Prime Minister, Cabinet or its Committees, and when one Department must consult and obtain the concurrence of another.

EXAM FOCUS — Fix these firmly

Both the AoB Rules and the ToB Rules are of **1961** and are made under **Article 77(3)**. They are available on the Cabinet Secretariat website. Do not confuse the two: **Allocation = who does what; Transaction = how it is decided / who is consulted**.

MEMORY TRICK

“ALLOT the work, TRANSACT the decision.” Allocation splits subjects among Departments; Transaction lays down the decision path and consultations.

Ministry / Department and its sub-units

A Ministry/Department frames policy on its allotted subjects and implements, monitors and reviews it. For efficient disposal it is divided into **Wings → Divisions → Branches → Sections/Units/Cells**. A Secretary heads the Department; a Wing is under a Special/Additional/Joint Secretary; a Division under a Director/Joint Director/Deputy Secretary (the “Division Head”); a Branch under an Under Secretary (the “Branch Officer”); and the Section — the lowest unit with a defined area of work — is supervised by a Section Officer.

The Desk Officer System

A notable variation is the Desk Officer system: work at the lowest level is organised into distinct functional 'desks', each manned by two desk functionaries of appropriate rank (e.g. Under Secretary or Section Officer) with support staff. A desk functionary deals with cases independently and submits directly to the next higher officer. Operationalising this system is one of the four reform planks of the 16th Edition.

Other kinds of Government organisations

Type	How created	Examples
Attached office	To give detailed executive direction for a Department's policy; a technical repository & adviser	e.g. field/technical directorates under a Ministry
Subordinate office	Field establishments that execute policy in detail	Regional / operational offices
Constitutional body	Under the Constitution itself	CAG, Election Commission, UPSC
Statutory body	Under an Act of Parliament	CVC, CIC, CBFC, NCBC
Autonomous body	By Government (usually a registered society), given autonomy under its Memorandum	CBSE, IIPA, IITs
Central PSE (CPSE)	Company under a Ministry, Govt holding >50% equity	BHEL, NTPC, ONGC; also AAI, FCI, CWC

CURRENCY ALERT — Terminology updated

The 16th Edition speaks of Central Public Sector Enterprises (CPSEs), defined by >50% Central-Government equity (subsidiaries with >50% CPSE equity are also CPSEs). Departmentally-run enterprises, banks and insurance companies are not CPSEs. Constitutional/statutory bodies are also treated as 'Regulatory Bodies' where they regulate a sector.

The Manual also recognises the **Integrated Headquarters of the Ministry of Defence** (Army/Naval/Air/Defence Staff Headquarters), which help frame defence policy and exercise delegated powers; and the **Information and Facilitation Counter (IFC)**, the public-facing counter that gives information on services and schemes, hands out forms, and receives, acknowledges and forwards grievances/applications.

Chapter 3

Functionaries and Functions

To maximise governance, powers are delegated down the hierarchy. Each functionary has a defined role; know 'who does what', because the examiners test it directly.

Functionary	Core role
Secretary	Administrative head & principal adviser to the Minister; responsibility complete and undivided; is the Chief Accounting Authority of the Department.
Special / Addl. / Joint Secretary	In charge of a Wing with the maximum measure of independent functioning, under the Secretary's overall responsibility.
Director / Deputy Secretary	Acts on behalf of the Secretary; holds a Division; disposes cases per delegated powers / channel of submission.
Under Secretary (Branch Officer)	In charge of a Branch (one or more Sections); disposes as many cases as possible himself; develops & maintains the 'aids to processing' (knowledge-management tools).
Desk Officer	A US or senior SO acting as desk functionary; decides independently with the powers of a US; can sign Orders, Financial Sanctions and affirm affidavits in court.
Section Officer (SO)	In charge of a Section; supervises dealing officers & support staff; distributes work, ensures discipline, timely reports/returns and person-independent records.
Assistant Section Officer (ASO) / Senior Secretariat Assistant (SSA)	The Dealing Officer: does initial examination, noting and drafting on the subjects allotted.
Junior Secretariat Assistant (JSA)	Support: dak registration, marking/sending receipts & files, record handling, photocopying; may do repetitive case-work.
Multi-Tasking Staff (MTS)	Erstwhile Group 'D' (peon, daftary, etc.): physical upkeep of records, carrying files, watch & ward, driving (if licensed), etc.

CURRENCY ALERT — A major terminology change — learn the new names

The old term 'Dealing Hand' (an Assistant or Upper Division Clerk) is replaced. The Dealing Officer is now the Assistant Section Officer (ASO) or Senior Secretariat Assistant (SSA); clerical support is the Junior Secretariat Assistant (JSA). 'Group D' posts are now Multi-Tasking Staff (MTS). If your old book says 'Dealing Hand / UDC / LDC', update it.

MEMORY TRICK — Hierarchy of a file's climb

Dealing Officer (ASO/SSA) → Section Officer → Under Secretary (Branch Officer) → Deputy Secretary/Director (Division Head) → Joint/Addl./Special Secretary → Secretary → Minister.

The Manual also lists the **Personal Staff of officers** — Principal Staff Officer / Sr. PPS / PPS (executive summaries, coordination, tour management, security of the officer's

information) and PS/PA/Stenographer Grade 'D' (dictation, telephone, visitors, confidential dak, parliamentary work). Detailed duties of a Section Officer are set out in Appendix 3.1 (general duties, dak, drafting, checks on delays, independent disposal, and recording/indexing) — importantly, the SO must now **ensure the e-file system is implemented and sustained** and ensure correct labelling of receipts (VIP/MP, RTI, PG).



Chapter 4

Decision Making in Government

CURRENCY ALERT — This is a new chapter in the 16th Edition

Chapter 4 did not exist as a separate chapter in older editions. It explains how decisions are actually taken in Government and how efficiency is to be improved. Expect fresh questions from here.

In a Parliamentary system the Council of Ministers is collectively responsible to the Lok Sabha, and the President acts on its advice. Under the **Transaction of Business Rules, 1961**, all business allotted to a Department is disposed of by (or under the direction of) the Minister-in-charge; and where a case concerns more than one Department, a decision can be taken only after the others have concurred, or the Cabinet/Cabinet Committee has decided.

Who is the 'competent authority'?

Financial and administrative powers are delegated through Acts, Rules, executive instructions and departmental instructions. So, to act on a case one must first find (a) the procedure to be followed and (b) who the competent authority is. Powers are generally delegated to the Secretary / Head of Department / Head of Office.

When a matter goes beyond a Department's powers

For decisions with financial implications beyond delegated powers, inter-ministerial consultation is required through bodies such as the Standing Finance Committee (SFC), Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC), Public Investment Board (PIB) and Public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (PPPAC), following the Ministry of Finance's instructions. For approval of the Committee of Secretaries, Group of Ministers, a Cabinet Committee or the Cabinet, the Cabinet Secretariat's guidelines apply.

EXAM FOCUS — Standard inter-ministerial consultations

Financial → Ministry of Finance; Personnel → DoPT (M/o Personnel, PG & Pensions); Legislation / rules / important contracts → Ministry of Law & Justice; External relations / treaties → Ministry of External Affairs; North-Eastern proposals → M/o DoNER; Economic matters → NITI Aayog.

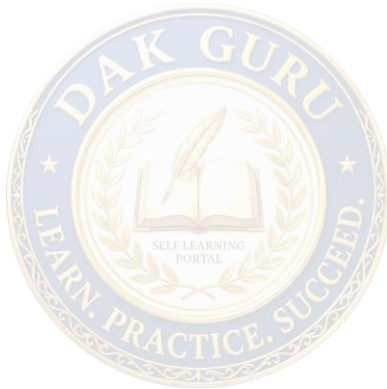
Categories of Government decisions

Decisions are of three kinds: **(a) legislative proposals; (b) policy issues; and (c) matters under the delegated powers of the Ministry.** A legislative proposal typically travels: brainstorm within the Department → stakeholder consultation → formulation → Inter-Ministerial Consultation (IMC) → approval of Cabinet/Cabinet Committee → introduction of the Bill → approval of Parliament → assent of the President. Decisions under delegated powers are taken by noting on a file (Chapter 7).

Efficiency in decision-making (para 4.9)

The Manual prescribes concrete steps to speed up decisions:

- Publish the channel of submission (except for classified cases) on the Department's website, and review the levels of disposal and channels of submission at least once in three years.
- Identify work that can be handled more efficiently through the Desk Officer System.
- Use the e-Office platform optimally, keep migrating to updated versions, and re-skill/up-skill officers and staff.
- Strengthen the Central Registration Unit (CRU) with the manpower and infrastructure needed for a digital secretariat.



Chapter 5

Management of Dak and Receipts

QUICK CONCEPT — Dak vs Receipt

'Dak' means all communications received or issued by an office. Once a communication is taken in for action, it is a 'Receipt'. The dak/receipt is the raw material of every file.

CURRENCY ALERT — Central Registry → Central Registration Unit (CRU)

The 16th Edition renames the receiving point the Central Registration Unit (CRU). Beyond registering dak, the CRU scans/digitises it into electronic receipts so the Department can work in e-Office. Strengthening and digitising CRUs is one of the four reform planks. (Dak may also be received at the Information & Facilitation Counter — IFC.)

Receipt of dak (para 5.1)

- During office hours, all dak — including that addressed to Ministers/officers by name — is received in the CRU/IFC. Urgency-graded dak sent by special messenger directly to an officer is received by the officer or their personal staff.
- If the officer is on leave/tour/training, has retired or been transferred, the successor / personal staff / Link Officer / next-below officer receives urgency-graded dak (except confidential letters). Immediate/important letters must never be left undelivered or returned.
- Outside office hours, 'Immediate' dak addressed by name may be delivered to the officer at residence (usually after a phone intimation); otherwise it is received by the night-duty clerk or a designated officer.
- E-mails are downloaded centrally by a designated person and forwarded to the CRU; e-mails to Ministers/officers are downloaded by them or their staff.

IN e-OFFICE / eFILE

In eFile, all physical dak — whether the Department works on paper or electronically — is received through e-Office in the Receipt inbox of the Receipt Section.

Scrutiny, registration & acknowledgement (paras 5.2–5.4)

- Urgency-graded dak is separated and dealt with first. All covers are opened by CRU/IFC except those addressed to an officer by name or bearing a security grading; missing enclosures are noted.
- Opened dak (and the covers of unopened classified dak) are date-stamped with the Department's name, date of receipt and CRU/IFC registration number, then sorted section-wise/officer-wise.
- Every dak is **registered at the entry level** for accountability, in the prescribed 'Dak Register', *except* a short exempt list — e.g. items covered by a special register

(telephone bills), MP communications (kept in a separate register), duplicate representations, casual-leave applications, and general circulars/holiday notices.

- Receipt of dak/files (except ordinary postal dak) is acknowledged by signing in ink in the messenger (peon) book with name, date and designation. In eFile, acknowledgement is auto-generated by SMS/e-mail if the sender's contact details were entered.

Distribution & disputed receipts (paras 5.5, 5.9)

- Urgency-graded dak is distributed as received; ordinary dak at fixed rounds — typically 11:00 AM, 2:00 PM and 4:00 PM. Sorting/registering should finish the same day; the balance passes to night-duty staff on signature.

EXAM FOCUS — Disputed receipts — remember the two deadlines

If a Section says a mis-sent receipt is not its concern, the matter goes to a designated Under Secretary, who must settle it within 2 working days from receipt in the Department — or, for urgency-graded receipts, within half a day.

Action on a receipt by the Dealing Officer (para 5.10)

The guiding objective is “**speed with accuracy**”, with paperwork kept to the essential minimum. The Dealing Officer (ASO/SSA) segregates urgency-graded receipts and deals with them first, checks enclosures, puts the receipt on a current file or opens a new one, uses knowledge-management tools (guard file, precedent book, reference folder) to link related papers, examines the issues and records a note, arranges papers, does referencing and docketing, attaches any urgency/security label, signs the note, and submits the file up the channel of submission.

DEPARTMENTAL ANGLE

In a DoP divisional/office setting the same flow applies — a receipt is diarised, put on the relevant file, examined and put up. Adopting eFile brings automatic receipt numbers, movement tracking and stand-alone dispatch to chase missing enclosures.

Chapter 6

File Management System

QUICK CONCEPT — What a file is

A file is a folder of related papers on one subject, with a file number. Its parts are: (i) Correspondence portion (incoming letters + office copies issued); (ii) Notes portion (the 'process sheet' showing how the decision was taken); (iii) Appendix to Correspondence (bulky enclosures); (iv) Appendix to Notes (long summaries/statements kept out of the main note).

The two file-numbering systems (para 6.2)

- (a) **Functional file numbering system** — developed by DARPG for functions common to all Departments, using standard heads: **Basic** → **Primary** → **Secondary** → **Tertiary heads**.
 (b) **Conventional (subject-classification) system** — a section-wise numbering that varies from Department to Department. Departments are encouraged to move from the conventional system to the uniform functional system.

EXAM FOCUS — Common office function codes (learn the letters)

A = Establishment; B = Welfare; C = Vigilance; D = Common office services; E = Hindi; F = Public relations; G = Finance, budget, cash & accounts; H = Parliament matters; I = RTI matters.

MEMORY TRICK

"A-B-C-D-E-F-G-H-I" → A(dmin/Estt), B(enefits=Welfare), C(vigilance), D(office services), E(=Hindi), F(PR), G(money), H(Parliament), I(RTI).

Filing of papers (para 6.6)

- Papers are punched at the left-hand top corner (leaving about 1 inch on top and left) and tagged into the correct part of the file in chronological order — oldest reference at the top, latest at the bottom.
- Notes and Correspondence portions are page-numbered separately and placed in a single file cover: the note-portion tag is fixed on the left, the correspondence-portion tag on the right.
- The latest PUC/FR may be kept on top temporarily for quick access, but must be page-numbered, referenced and docketed, and transferred back to the bottom once action is decided, to preserve chronological order.

EXAM FOCUS — When a file becomes a 'Volume'

When the notes plus correspondence become bulky — say they exceed 150–200 pages — the file is stitched and marked 'Volume I'; further papers go into 'Volume II', and so on. Page numbering in later volumes continues from the last page of the previous volume. (In eFile, no new volume is needed.)

Arrangement of papers in a case (Box 6.1)

From top downwards: (1) Acts/Rules/reference books; (2) Notes portion ending with the note for consideration; (3) Draft for approval, if any; (4) Correspondence portion ending with the latest receipt/issue or the running summary of facts; (5) Appendix to notes & correspondence; (6) Standing Guard File / Precedent Book / Reference Folder; (7) other referred papers (latest on top); (8) recorded files (latest on top); (9) routine notes/papers in a separate cover.

Referencing & docketing (paras 6.7–6.8)

- **Referencing** — each page in every part is numbered in a separate series at the top-right; the paper under consideration is flagged 'PUC' and the latest fresh receipt noted upon is 'FR' (FR I, FR II...). File numbers, and the section/rule/order references, are quoted in the body of the note so they can be traced after slips are removed.
- **Docketing** — making entries in the notes portion of the serial number given to each item of correspondence (receipt 'R' or issue 'I') for identification; any remark of a senior officer on the receipt is reproduced before the note. Docket numbers appear in **red ink** at the top-middle of each item of correspondence.

IN e-OFFICE / eFILE

In eFile, page numbers in notes and correspondence are auto-generated; a receipt can be marked 'PUC'/'FR' (fixed once assigned); linking a page reference is enough — physical flags are unnecessary.

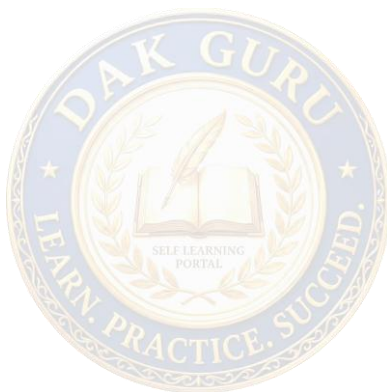
Linking, part files, transfer & movement (paras 6.9–6.12)

- **Linking vs attaching:** a *linked* file is one where a decision is needed; an *attached* file is only for reference. Linked files are stacked and delinked after action, taking relevant extracts.
- **Part file:** opened when the main file is unavailable and a fresh receipt cannot wait; identified as PF-1, PF-2... and merged back into the main file after fresh referencing.
- **Transfer/reconstruction:** on transfer of work, all records (current and closed) move to the new Section, which must not reclassify or renumber closed files; a lost file is reconstructed from the file register and copies of correspondence, with a self-contained note.
- Movement of files is entered in the File Movement Register (or tracked automatically in e-Office).

Urgency grading (para 6.13)

EXAM FOCUS — The three urgency labels

The urgency gradings are '**Immediate**', '**Priority**' and '**Top Priority**'. 'Immediate' = needs prompt attention; 'Priority' = disposal in precedence to ordinary cases; 'Top Priority' = extremely urgent. For Lok Sabha/Rajya Sabha questions, motions and Bills a separate specific file cover is used (in eFile the label "VIP" is used for RS/LS matters), so no other urgency grading is needed. Grading is reviewed and revised at each stage.



Chapter 7

Guidelines on Noting

QUICK CONCEPT — What a 'note' is

A note is the remarks recorded on a case to help examine it and reach a decision — the reasoning that culminates in an order. Good noting is concise, relevant and self-contained.

Guidelines for noting (para 7.2)

- All notes are concise and to the point; extra material goes to an appendix, not the main note.
- Ink: only **black or blue** ink is used for handwritten noting by all categories of staff and officers. In e-Office, a digital signature is appended at each level.
- The Dealing Officer signs on the left, below the note, with full signature, name and date; an officer signs on the right, with name, designation and date.
- Notes for the Cabinet / Cabinet Committees / GoM / Committee of Secretaries follow the format prescribed by the Cabinet Secretariat.

Level of disposal and channel of submission (para 7.6)

EXAM FOCUS — The 'levels' rule — a layering favourite

Each Department lays down, and places in the public domain, a scheme of delegation so that a decision is taken at the most appropriate level. As a general rule the number of levels through which a case passes for a decision should not exceed four. The layering reform pushes Departments to keep the levels to the minimum. Where a level is 'jumped', the case, on return, passes through the levels jumped over.

CURRENCY ALERT — Verify the exact figure before the exam

The 'not more than four levels' rule comes from the CSMOP framework (para 7.6, carried from the 2019 edition into 2022, which even cross-refers to 'para 7.6 of CSMOP, 2019'). Because the whole thrust of the 16th Edition is layering, confirm the exact wording in your current CSMOP copy if a question turns on the precise number.

Oral discussions, oral instructions & modification of notes (paras 7.9–7.13)

- Points and conclusions from any discussion (including telephonic) are recorded on the file at the earliest by the officer authorising action, and got confirmed by the participants where important.
- If an officer acts on a superior's oral direction, they get it in writing before acting where practicable, or obtain written confirmation as soon as possible. Oral orders on behalf of a Minister are confirmed in writing immediately; oral orders not in accordance with rules require the Secretary's clear written orders.
- **Modification of notes:** seniors do not alter or replace a junior's note once submitted — they record their own note. Pasting over a note to conceal it is forbidden; a

correcting note is added, keeping the earlier note intact. Withdrawing a decision already communicated (found to rest on a mistake) needs the approval of an officer higher than the one who took it, with reasons recorded.

IN e-OFFICE / eFILE

In eFile the 'functional approach to noting' (para 7.14) and running summary of facts are supported; standard process sheets are used for repetitive cases (e.g. leave, advances) so that no separate note is needed.



Chapter 8

Communication — Forms, Channels and Procedure

Forms of written communication (Appendix 8.1)

Form	When used / key feature
Letter	Formal correspondence with other governments, bodies, public and offices outside the Department.
Demi-official (D.O.) letter	Officer-to-officer, semi-formal, first-person; to draw personal attention or exchange views.
Office Memorandum (O.M.)	Correspondence between Departments, and to attached/subordinate offices; impersonal third person.
Inter-Departmental (I.D.) Note	Consulting another Department on a file. (Earlier called the 'U.O. Note' — renamed I.D. Note in recent editions.)
Office Order	Usually for internal administration (postings, distribution of work, leave).
Order	To convey a Government decision, often in disciplinary/financial matters.
Notification	To notify statutory rules/orders; published in the Gazette of India.
Resolution	To announce Government policy or decisions of importance (e.g. constituting a committee).
Press Communiqué / Note	For issue to the press; a communiqué is more formal than a press note.
Endorsement	To forward a copy of a communication to others.
Minutes	Record of a meeting: date/venue, chair, participants, conclusions and the Department responsible for follow-up.

CURRENCY ALERT — 'U.O. Note' is now the 'Inter-Departmental (I.D.) Note'

If your old notes call it a 'U.O. Note', update the name to Inter-Departmental Note. The 16th Edition also emphasises e-mail as a normal channel (with pdf plus editable Word/Excel where information is furnished) and covers the composition of, and material for, the Gazette of India (Appendix 8.2).

Single File System (SFS) (para 8.7)

The SFS applies when a Non-Secretariat Office (NSO) — e.g. an attached/subordinate office — must refer a matter to its Department for a sanction/order beyond its own delegated powers. The NSO's file is completed in all respects (every point for decision brought out, connected papers arranged, draft sanctions put up, funds certified), routed through the Department's central registry, and — as a rule — the secretariat notes on the NSO file itself. Action to implement the decision is taken by the NSO on return of the file, stating that Government's concurrence has been obtained.

Correspondence with various authorities (paras 8.6–8.8)

- Attached/subordinate offices ordinarily route matters needing another Ministry's approval through their parent Department, but may correspond directly with Departments like Expenditure, Personnel or Health for clarifications on rules/guidelines.
- References to the Attorney-General are made through the Ministry of Law & Justice; to constitutional/statutory authorities (ECI, UPSC, etc.) usually by letter to their Secretary; to the CAG through the Ministry of Finance (day-to-day matters may be direct).
- Correspondence with State Governments/UT Administrations is normally addressed to the Secretary of the relevant Department, or the Chief Secretary/Administrator for important matters; a D.O. to a Chief Secretary is at least at Joint Secretary level.

EXAM FOCUS — MP / VIP correspondence — the key rule

Communications from Members of Parliament and VIPs are attended to promptly. A letter to a Minister is, as far as possible, replied to by the Minister; otherwise replies are signed at the appropriate senior level, and the minimum level for a reply to an MP/VIP is Under Secretary, in letter form. Information sought by an MP/VIP is supplied unless it could have been refused on the floor of the House. (Monitoring of MP/VIP letters and the acknowledgement/reply time-frame are dealt with in Chapter 12.)

- Prompt response to letters (para 8.9) and use of the official language (para 8.10) in communications are separately emphasised.

Chapter 9

Guidelines on Drafting of Communications

QUICK CONCEPT — What a 'draft' is

A draft is the rough version of the communication to be issued, approved before a fair copy is signed and sent. A draft is not needed in straightforward cases or where a standard form of communication already exists.

General instructions for drafting (para 9.2)

- A draft is clear and concise.
- It refers to the number and date of the last communication in the series (and, if that was not from the addressee, the addressee's last communication on the subject). Multiple references go in the margin. When two or more communications issue from the same file on the same date, a serial number is inserted before the year in the number to avoid confusion.
- The signing officer's name, designation, telephone/fax number and e-mail (where applicable) are given in the communication.

Authentication of Government orders (para 9.3)

EXAM FOCUS — Authentication — the two rules to remember

All orders and instruments made in the name of the **President** are expressed to be made in his name and signed by an officer of/above the rank of **Under Secretary** (or otherwise authorised) under the **Authentication (Orders and Other Instruments) Rules, 2002**. Where a statute confers the power, the order/notification is expressed to be made in the name of the **Government of India**.

Addressing officers by name & responsibility mapping (paras 9.4–9.6)

- Normally no communication (other than a classified one or a D.O. letter) is addressed to an officer by name, unless the matter needs the officer's personal attention because of its special nature, urgency, importance or a prior personal discussion.
- The 16th Edition adds 'responsibility mapping' for issue of communications — who approves what (e.g. information to be uploaded on portals like PRAGATI, maintenance of Stamps Accounts Register), listed in Appendix 1.1 as matters for Departmental Instructions.

Chapter 10

Records Management

QUICK CONCEPT — The life-cycle of a record

Records management covers recording (closing an actioned file), retention, retrieval, review/weeding, and finally transfer of the valuable ones to the National Archives of India (NAI). Its aim: files are neither destroyed too early nor kept longer than necessary.

Recording, indexing & categorisation (paras 10.2–10.6)

- A file is recorded (closed) after action on it is complete, governed by the Record Retention Schedule (RRS) and NAI provisions; useful extracts/decisions are added to the standing guard file / precedent book.
- **Categories of records** (as prescribed by NAI): **Category 'A'** — to be microfilmed/kept permanently (historical or continuing value); **Category 'B'** — to be retained for a specified long period; **Category 'C'** — to be reviewed and weeded periodically (retained a limited period).

Record Retention Schedule (RRS) (para 10.7)

Every Ministry/Department follows three streams of retention rules:

- **Accounts records** — as per the retention provisions of the **General Financial Rules (GFR), 2017** (which superseded the GFR, 2005).
- **Common establishment/housekeeping records** — as per the **Record Retention Schedule for Records Common to All Ministries/Departments** (the RRS, 2012, issued by DARPG), as amended.
- **Substantive-function records** — a **Departmental Retention Schedule** issued by the Department in consultation with the NAI.

CURRENCY ALERT — Two things to update here

- 1) Record management practices were refreshed by DARPG's O.M. No. Q-15011/1/2025-O&M dated 1 August 2025 (read with the Public Records Act, 1993 and the Public Records Rules, 1997, and Chapter 10 of CSMOP 2022) — cite the 2025 O.M. as the latest guidance.
- 2) The exact GFR-2017 appendix number for destruction of accounts records should be confirmed against your current GFR copy: the old GFR (1963/2005) used 'Appendix 13'; the reference was re-numbered when the GFR was recast in 2017. Treat any specific appendix number in older notes as needing verification.

Custody, review, requisition & Ministers' records (paras 10.8–10.13)

- A classified file is reviewed once in **five years** for declassification; a declassified file fit for permanent preservation is transferred to the National Archives.
- Progress of recording and review is watched through quarterly and consolidated monthly reports (formats in the Appendices to Chapter 10).

- No recorded file is issued from a Section/Record Room/Archives except against a requisition in the form prescribed under the **Public Records Act, 1993**; records bearing a security classification are not transferred to the Archives (Section 10 of that Act).
- Personal offices of Ministers keep the necessary records (diary, dispatch and file-movement registers); when a file is given to the Minister informally, the PS to Minister watches its movement and return.



Chapter 11

Knowledge Management

CURRENCY ALERT — A new chapter in the 16th Edition

Knowledge Management is now a full chapter. It groups the 'aids to processing' — tools that make the office 'person-independent', so knowledge survives transfers and retirements. This aligns with Mission Karmayogi (NPCSCB).

The 'aids to processing' (tools of knowledge management) that each Section maintains, physically and/or on the system, are:

Tool	What it is / why it matters
Note for the Successor	A hand-over note the outgoing officer prepares so the successor can take charge without loss of continuity.
Standard Process Sheet	A pre-structured format for repetitive cases (leave, advances, HBA) so no fresh note is needed each time.
Standing Guard File	A self-contained compilation of the rules, orders and precedents on a subject, kept up to date.
Standing Note	A continuously-updated running account of the history and current position of a subject.
Precedent Book	A record of important rulings and decisions of precedent value, for ready reference.
Reference Folder	A folder of frequently-needed reference material for a subject.
Induction Material	Material to orient a newly-posted functionary to the Section's work.
Master Circular	A consolidation of all live instructions on a subject into one circular — a 16th-Edition emphasis for clarity and access.

EXAM FOCUS — Guard File vs Precedent Book vs Standing Note

Guard File = the rules/orders compilation on a subject. Precedent Book = important decisions/rulings of precedent value. Standing Note = the running history & current position. Note for the Successor = the hand-over note. Master Circular = all live instructions consolidated.

The chapter also sets out 'responsibility mapping' — clearly fixing who maintains and updates each tool — so that knowledge is retained and transferred rather than lost with an individual.

Chapter 12

Monitoring of Timely Disposal

QUICK CONCEPT — Why this chapter exists

Speed is half of 'speed with accuracy'. This chapter fixes time limits and monitoring for ordinary cases and for special categories — MP/VIP references, court/CAT cases, RTI, Parliamentary Assurances and periodical reports.

Time limits for disposal (para 12.2)

EXAM FOCUS — The 7-day rule

Departments fix time limits for as many types of cases as possible through departmental instructions. As a general rule, no functionary should keep a case pending for more than 7 working days unless a higher limit is prescribed for that type of case. If a case stays longer, the reason is recorded on the note portion. An exception-reporting system monitors disposal.

MP / VIP references (para 12.3)

EXAM FOCUS — The acknowledgement & reply time-frame

Each communication from a Member of Parliament / VIP is **acknowledged within 15 days**, followed by a **reply within the next 15 days** of the acknowledgement. A watch is kept through a separate register; letters pending over a fortnight are specially listed. The same care applies to judicial/quasi-judicial matters.

MEMORY TRICK

MP/VIP = "15 + 15" — acknowledge in 15 days, reply in the next 15.

Court/CAT, RTI, Assurances, reports & websites (paras 12.4–12.9)

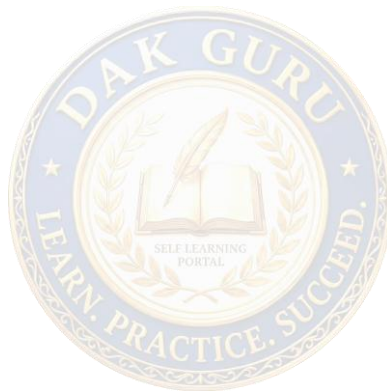
- Court/CAT cases and implementation of their orders are tracked in a dedicated register; delay can invite contempt.
- Requests under the **Right to Information Act, 2005** are dealt with within that Act's timelines (ordinarily 30 days) and monitored separately.
- Parliamentary Assurances are entered in a Register and pursued until fulfilled; periodical reports/returns are watched through incoming/outgoing check-lists and reviewed to prune needless returns.
- Websites are monitored for up-to-date content in compliance with the **Guidelines for Indian Government Websites (GIGW)**; a nodal officer is appointed and the site is audited (STQC) for a GIGW certificate.

CURRENCY ALERT — GIGW has moved on

The GIGW referenced in the Manual is now maintained by MeitY/NIC and has been revised (GIGW 3.0). The Manual's older website addresses (e.g. 'deity.nic.in', 'darpn.nic.in') have largely migrated to 'meity.gov.in' and 'darpn.gov.in'. Treat portal URLs in the Manual as liable to change.

Disposal of Pending Matters (para 12.10)

The 16th Edition institutionalises the 'Special Campaign for Disposal of Pending Matters' (Swachhta / cleanliness campaigns), with weekly activity and monthly monitoring/review, to clear physical files, references, MP/VIP letters and grievances in a time-bound way.



Chapter 13

Security of Official Information and Documents

Communication of official information (para 13.1)

Every Government servant, acting in good faith in the discharge of duties, communicates to a member of the public or an organisation full and accurate information that can be disclosed under the **Right to Information Act, 2005**. This does not permit disclosure of classified information in an unauthorised manner or for improper gain.

Treatment & handling of classified papers (paras 13.2–13.3)

- Classified papers are handled under the **Departmental Security Instructions** of the Ministry of Home Affairs. Classified papers (other than 'Confidential') are normally handled by officers themselves or in sections designated 'Secret'/'Top Secret'; in other sections the Section Officer personally maintains separate registers and does the recording/review.
- For carrying classified papers outside office: an officer not below **Section/Desk Officer** may carry *Confidential* papers; not below **Under Secretary** may carry *Secret* papers — only in special circumstances and with the written authorisation of a Joint-Secretary-level officer, produced on demand.

EXAM FOCUS — Two figures to keep straight

Declassification review of a classified file: once in five years (Chapter 10). Confidential I.D. notes/files retain their confidential character. Carrying papers out: Confidential → SO/Desk Officer level; Secret → US level (with JS authorisation).

Communication to the press & restrictive classification (paras 13.4–13.5)

- Official information to the press/media normally goes through the Press Information Bureau (PIB); only Ministers, Secretaries and specifically authorised officers may speak to the press — others direct the press to the PIB or seek the Secretary's permission.
- 'For official use only' is not assigned to a printed report/compilation unless disclosure would not be in the public interest; a useful test is whether the Minister would be justified in refusing to lay it before Parliament. Marking a publication 'For official use only' needs the branch officer's approval (Secretary/Minister in doubtful cases).

Chapter 14

Annual Action Plan & Citizen's / Client's Charter

Annual Action Plan (para 14.1)

Each Department prepares an Annual Action Plan translating its goals into time-bound, measurable activities with responsibilities fixed, and reviews progress — a management tool for the year's work.

Citizen's / Client's Charter (para 14.2)

QUICK CONCEPT — What a Citizen's Charter is

A public document in which an organisation declares its commitments to citizens/clients on the standards of service, information, choice & consultation, non-discrimination & accessibility, grievance redress, courtesy and value for money. It is displayed prominently (website, IFC notice board).

A good Charter contains: the vision & mission; the business transacted; who the citizens/clients are; the services with standards, quality and time-frames (and how/where to get them); the grievance-redress mechanism and how to access it; what is expected from citizens; and any additional commitment such as compensation for service failure. The format is in the Sevottam framework of DARPG.

Public Grievance Redressal & CPGRAMS (paras 14.3–14.8)

CURRENCY ALERT — This is the most-updated part of the Manual — learn the current position

Grievances are handled through **CPGRAMS** (Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System, www.pgportal.gov.in) — a single 24×7 portal linking all Central Ministries/Departments, States and UTs.

The 16th Edition introduced **Nodal Appellate Authorities (NAA)** (an officer of Additional/Joint Secretary rank), with Sub-Appellate Authorities (SAA) under them for localised appeals.

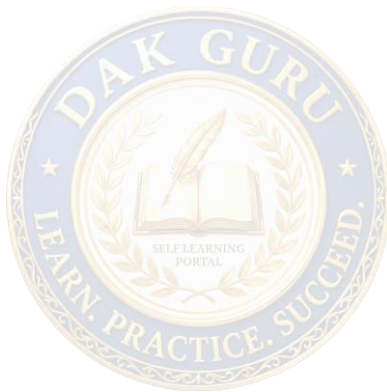
Timeline reduced **30 → 21 days** by DARPG's **Comprehensive Guidelines for Effective Redressal of Public Grievances dated 23 August 2024** (an interim reply is sent if more time is needed).

“Whole-of-Government” rule: a grievance must **not** be closed merely by saying “does not pertain to this Ministry/Department”.

After resolution, a Feedback Call Centre contacts the citizen to assess satisfaction; if unsatisfied, the citizen can file an appeal (portal, chatbot, WhatsApp, call centre) — only a single appeal per grievance. The platform has advanced through **CPGRAMS 7.0**, with **NextGen CPGRAMS** launched on 1 July 2025 (WhatsApp/chatbot filing, voice-to-text, auto-escalation, AI-assisted replies). Some grievance categories are not taken up (e.g. sub-judice matters, RTI matters, personal/family disputes, and matters governed by CVC/DoPT vigilance procedure).

DEPARTMENTAL ANGLE

For the Department of Posts, service standards flow into its own Citizen's Charter, and public complaints are routed through CPGRAMS as well as departmental complaint channels; the 21-day norm and the no-'does-not-pertain' rule apply.



Chapter 15

eOffice Digitization Framework

CURRENCY ALERT — A new chapter in the 16th Edition

Chapter 15 is a fresh, dedicated framework for turning physical records into a digital secretariat, supporting e-Office Version 7.0. It is very likely to be examined as a stand-alone topic.

Governance & the three phases (paras 15.1–15.2)

Digitisation is driven by a governance structure within the Department and proceeds in **three phases: Phase 1 – Plan** (assess volume, prioritise, resource); **Phase 2 – Prepare** (organise files, set standards, ready the CRU/scanners); **Phase 3 – Implement** (scan, capture metadata, store and integrate into e-Office).

Scanning, metadata & storage (para 15.3)

- Mode of scanning, scanning specifications and format are standardised; all pages of a single dak are scanned into a single pdf document.
- Metadata is entered so documents are searchable and retrievable; storage and storage-format guidelines, quality-control checks, security guidelines and user training are prescribed.
- The digitised records are integrated into e-Office (para 15.4) so that receipts, files, movement and search all work electronically; the CRU is the backbone of this process, needing skilled manpower and high-speed ADF scanners.

EXAM FOCUS — Remember the framework at a glance

Governance structure → 3 phases (Plan / Prepare / Implement) → scan (single pdf per dak) + metadata + secure storage → integrate into e-Office (v7.0). CRU is the backbone.

Chapter 16

Inspection

CURRENCY ALERT — A new chapter in the 16th Edition

Inspection is now a dedicated chapter with ready-made questionnaires. It replaces scattered older inspection instructions and is aligned to e-Office.

Purpose, periodicity & teams (paras 16.1–16.4)

- Inspection checks that the Manual and Departmental Instructions are actually being followed, locates common defects and suggests remedies; the process has been simplified and made largely e-Office-based.
- Inspections are carried out by designated teams/authorities on a fixed programme (with surprise inspections), and supervisory officers also conduct periodic inspections of the sections/staff under them.

Inspection Report & follow-up (paras 16.5–16.7)

- Findings are put in an Inspection Report submitted to the level fixed by Departmental Instructions; a supplementary inspection follows up on compliance.
- Standard questionnaires are provided for: a Department's e-Office implementation; a CRU where e-Office has commenced; a Departmental Record Room; a Section/Desk; and a personal section/staff.

DEPARTMENTAL ANGLE

This mirrors the inspection culture already familiar in India Post (divisional/office inspections), now oriented to check e-Office readiness, CRU digitisation and records upkeep.

Glossary

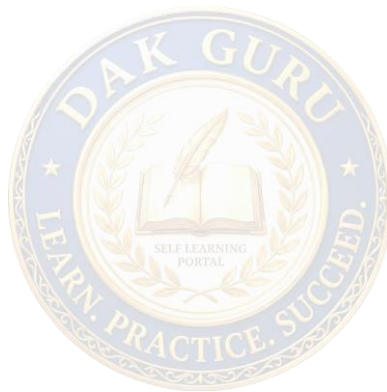
Glossary of Key Terms

EXAM FOCUS — Where definitions live now

The 16th Edition places all definitions in a Glossary at the end of the Manual (older editions had a separate 'Definitions' chapter). The terms below are the ones examiners quote most often.

Term	Meaning (as used in the CSMOP)
Dak	All communications received or issued by an office/Department.
Receipt	A communication (dak) once taken in for action on a case.
Case	A current file, or a receipt together with related papers.
Current file	A file on which action is not yet complete.
File	A folder of related papers on one subject, with a number; parts: Notes, Correspondence, Appendix to Notes, Appendix to Correspondence.
PUC (Paper Under Consideration)	The receipt whose consideration is the subject matter of the case.
FR (Fresh Receipt)	A later receipt on a case bringing additional information (FR I, FR II...).
Note	The remarks recorded on a case to help examine it and reach a decision.
Docketing	Entering, in the notes portion, the serial number of each item of correspondence (R/I) for identification.
Referencing	Numbering pages and quoting file numbers / rule references so papers can be traced.
Dealing Officer	The functionary doing initial examination — now the ASO / SSA (replaces 'Dealing Hand').
CRU (Central Registration Unit)	The unit that receives, registers and digitises all dak (replaces the old 'Central Registry').
IFC (Information & Facilitation Counter)	The public-facing counter for information, forms and grievances.
Minute	A note recorded by the President, Vice-President, Prime Minister or a Minister.
Link Officer	An officer designated to deal with an absent officer's urgent work.
Standard Process Sheet	A pre-structured format for repetitive cases (no fresh note needed).
Standing Guard File	A self-contained, up-to-date compilation of rules/orders/precedents on a subject.
Precedent Book	A record of important rulings/decisions of precedent value.

Single File System (SFS)	A system for a Non-Secretariat Office to refer a matter to its Department on one file.
Department	A Ministry/Department/Secretariat/Office in the First Schedule to the AoB Rules, 1961, as amended.



Verification Record

Currency & Verification Record (as on August 2026)

Every currency-sensitive point in these notes was checked against primary and official sources before writing. The main findings, and what changed from the 15th-Edition version of these notes, are recorded below so you can judge the currency for yourself and re-verify if needed.

Point	Position adopted in these notes	Basis / source
Edition in force	16th Edition — CSMOP, 2022 (the 15th-Edition, 2019, is superseded)	DARPG CSMOP 2022 (Foreword by Secy DARPG, 13.07.2022); shown current on DARPG/DPAR site as on 01.03.2026
Structure	16 chapters + Glossary; new chapters 4, 11, 15, 16	Table of Contents, CSMOP 2022
Reform thrust	Delaying, Delegation, Desk Officer System, CRU digitisation, e-Office v7.0	Foreword & press statement, CSMOP 2022 (Aug 2022)
Dak unit	Central Registration Unit (CRU); dak is scanned/digitised	Ch 5 & Appendix 5.2, CSMOP 2022
Lowest functionaries	Dealing Officer = ASO/SSA; support = JSA; MTS	Ch 3, CSMOP 2022
Grievance timeline	Reduced 30 → 21 days; Nodal Appellate Authorities; no 'does-not-pertain' closure	DARPG Comprehensive Guidelines dated 23.08.2024; PIB/CPGRAMS
CPGRAMS platform	CPGRAMS 7.0; NextGen CPGRAMS launched 01.07.2025	DARPG / PIB, 2024–2025
Records management	Refreshed guidance via DARPG O.M. dated 01.08.2025 (with Public Records Act 1993 / Rules 1997)	DARPG O.M. No. Q-15011/1/2025-O&M, 01.08.2025
Authentication of orders	Authentication (Orders & Other Instruments) Rules, 2002; signed by US & above	Ch 9, CSMOP 2022
GIGW / URLs	GIGW revised (v3.0, MeitY/NIC); Manual's older URLs migrated to *.gov.in	MeitY GIGW; flagged as liable to change

CURRENCY ALERT — Points deliberately flagged for your own re-verification

- 'Not more than four levels' of disposal (Ch 7) — carried from the CSMOP framework (para 7.6, 2019 cross-referenced in 2022); confirm the exact number in your CSMOP copy if a question turns on it, given the delaying reform.

- The precise GFR-2017 appendix for destruction of accounts records — old GFR used 'Appendix 13'; the reference was recast in GFR 2017. Verify the current number rather than relying on an older figure.
- '7 working days' pendency (Ch 12) and 'MP/VIP 15 + 15 days' (Ch 12) — standard CSMOP provisions retained; treat as current unless your Department's instructions prescribe otherwise.



Primary & official sources consulted

- Central Secretariat Manual of Office Procedure, 16th Edition (CSMOP, 2022) — Department of Administrative Reforms & Public Grievances (DARPG), Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances & Pensions.
- DARPG, Comprehensive Guidelines for Effective Redressal of Public Grievances, dated 23 August 2024 (grievance-redressal timeline reduced to 21 days; Nodal Appellate Authorities).
- DARPG, O.M. No. Q-15011/1/2025-O&M dated 1 August 2025 — Record Management Practices (read with Chapter 10, CSMOP 2022).
- Public Records Act, 1993 and Public Records Rules, 1997.
- General Financial Rules, 2017 (Ministry of Finance, Department of Expenditure) — for retention of accounts records.
- Authentication (Orders and Other Instruments) Rules, 2002 (Ministry of Home Affairs).
- Government of India (Allocation of Business) Rules, 1961 and (Transaction of Business) Rules, 1961 (Cabinet Secretariat).
- Guidelines for Indian Government Websites (GIGW), MeitY / NIC (current version).
- CPGRAMS portal (www.pgportal.gov.in) and DARPG/PIB releases on CPGRAMS 7.0 and NextGen CPGRAMS (2024–2025).

— End of Notes —

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